



The AI Sales Co-Pilot that makes sure no lead ever gets missed

# ZOL Investment Memorandum

Prepared for: Prospective Investors

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## Introduction

ZOL is an AI-native sales execution layer for automotive dealerships. It autonomously engages, qualifies, and follows up with inbound leads via voice, SMS, and email until an appointment is booked - replacing manual BDC workflows with 24/7 intelligent automation.

By increasing response speed and follow-up persistence, ZOL directly converts lost leads into booked showroom traffic and measurable revenue lift.

## Investment Highlights

- 10 active dealership design partners validating product-market fit with zero churn
- Each rooftop receives ~700 inbound leads monthly — creating high-velocity AI engagement volume
- \$500/month per rooftop SaaS model with expansion across multi-brand and multi-city dealer groups
- Path to \$1M ARR at 167 rooftops; scalable to \$360M US TAM across ~60,000 rooftops

- Capital-efficient founder-led GTM with early dealer group partnerships
- \$500K raise to achieve \$80K MRR and establish repeatable, high-margin vertical SaaS motion

## Problem

Automotive dealerships generate hundreds of high-intent inbound leads per rooftop every month, yet a meaningful percentage go unconverted due to delayed responses, inconsistent follow-up, and limited BDC bandwidth.

Manual BDC teams are expensive, operate within fixed hours, and struggle to persist across multi-touch engagement sequences. Studies consistently show that response delays of even minutes materially reduce appointment booking probability.

For a dealership receiving ~700 inbound leads per month, missed follow-ups directly translate into lost appointments and lost vehicle sales - representing tens of thousands of dollars in unrealized gross profit per rooftop annually.

## Why Now

### 1. AI Infrastructure Is Now Production-Ready

Voice, SMS, and LLM costs have dropped significantly, making autonomous engagement economically viable at scale.

### 2. Digital Lead Volume Has Increased

Dealerships now receive hundreds of inbound digital leads per rooftop each month, increasing follow-up complexity.

### 3. Rising BDC Labor Costs

Traditional BDC staffing is expensive, inconsistent, and difficult to scale across multi-rooftop groups.

### 4. API-Enabled CRM Ecosystem

Modern dealership CRMs and DMS platforms now allow integration layers, enabling AI-native automation.

The convergence of AI reliability, infrastructure cost reduction, and dealership digital transformation makes full sales automation viable today.

## Solution

ZOL replaces manual lead engagement workflows with autonomous multimodal AI agents that engage every inbound lead instantly via voice, SMS, and email.

The system executes dealership-specific playbooks, adapts follow-up timing and messaging dynamically, and persists until an appointment is booked or the lead is disqualified.

By combining immediate response speed with structured multi-touch persistence, ZOL converts lost leads into booked showroom traffic - creating measurable revenue uplift while reducing reliance on traditional BDC staffing.

## Product Workflow

ZOL integrates directly into dealership CRM or DMS systems and automates the full inbound engagement lifecycle:

- 1. Lead Capture**  
Inbound leads flow automatically from CRM, DMS, website forms, or third-party marketplaces.
- 2. Instant AI Engagement**  
Multimodal AI agents initiate engagement via voice, SMS, and email within seconds of lead submission — eliminating response delays.
- 3. Adaptive Follow-Up Orchestration**  
AI executes dealership-specific playbooks, adjusting messaging cadence, tone, and channel dynamically based on prospect behavior.
- 4. Appointment Scheduling & Logging**  
Qualified leads are booked directly into dealership calendars and synced back into CRM systems for sales team visibility.

# Competitive Landscape

The dealership communication and CRM ecosystem includes established vendors and emerging AI tools:

**Podium** – Primarily a messaging and reputation management platform. Focused on reviews, website chat, and customer messaging, not full autonomous lead qualification and appointment orchestration.

**Pam AI** – AI receptionist focused on call handling, but limited in multi-channel orchestration and dealership-specific workflow depth.

**FLAI** – AI-based engagement platform, but operates primarily as automated follow-up rather than a fully integrated, dealership-trained appointment execution system.

**Legacy CRMs (VinSolutions, DealerSocket, CDK, Reynolds)** – Core CRM/DMS systems with rule-based automation and limited AI capabilities.

## Why ZOL Wins

### 1. Appointment Execution, Not Just Messaging

ZOL autonomously drives leads to booked appointments using dealership-specific playbooks.

### 2. Native CRM & DMS Integration

Built around real BDC workflows, not generic AI chat layered on top.

### 3. True Multichannel Orchestration

Voice, SMS, and email coordinated under one AI agent system.

### 4. Proprietary Dealership Data Loop

Continuous iteration with live dealers improves follow-up logic and conversion performance.

### 5. Vertical Depth

Focused exclusively on automotive dealerships, enabling deeper optimization and stronger ROI than horizontal tools.

# Defensibility

ZOL’s competitive advantage strengthens over time through four reinforcing layers:

**1. Proprietary Conversation Dataset**

Each rooftop generates structured engagement data that continuously improves booking logic and objection handling.

**2. Rooftop-Specific Playbooks**

Custom workflows embedded into dealership operations increase switching costs.

**3. CRM / DMS Integration Layer**

Deep operational integration makes ZOL infrastructure, not a surface tool.

**4. Multi-Rooftop Expansion**

Dealer group expansion compounds retention and lowers acquisition cost per rooftop.

# Market Opportunity

The U.S. automotive retail market includes approximately **60,000 dealership rooftops**, including both franchise and independent dealers.

ZOL is priced at **\$500 per rooftop per month (\$6,000 ARR per rooftop)**.

| Metric                                | Calculation                   | Value                    |
|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>TAM (Total Addressable Market)</b> | 60,000 rooftops × \$6,000 ARR | <b>\$360,000,000 ARR</b> |
| <b>\$1M ARR Milestone</b>             | 167 rooftops × \$6,000 ARR    | <b>\$1,002,000 ARR</b>   |
| <b>Initial Beachhead (SOM)</b>        | 1,000 rooftops × \$6,000 ARR  | <b>\$6,000,000 ARR</b>   |

# Additional Revenue Leverage

- Many dealership groups operate **multiple rooftops (1–5 per group)**
- Larger dealer groups operate **10+ rooftops across cities**
- Used-only independent dealerships follow identical inbound lead dynamics

Because revenue scales per rooftop, dealer group expansion meaningfully accelerates ARR growth.

## Business Model

### Pricing

Flat **\$500 per rooftop per month**  
(\$6,000 ARR per rooftop)

Average dealership: **1–5 rooftops**  
Enterprise dealer groups: 10+ rooftops

### Unit Economics

| Category                      | Calculation              | Cost / Value   |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------|----------------|
| Assumptions                   |                          |                |
| Monthly inbound leads         | 700                      |                |
| Projected Engagement          |                          |                |
| Leads receiving AI call       | 280                      |                |
| Avg. call duration            | 3 minutes                |                |
| Leads receiving SMS follow-up | 420                      |                |
| Avg. SMS messages per lead    | 3 SMS                    |                |
| Variable Cost Analysis        |                          |                |
| Voice Cost                    |                          |                |
| Total Call Minutes            | 280 calls × 3 min        | 840 minutes    |
| Voice Cost                    | 840 minutes × \$0.10/min | <b>\$84.00</b> |
| SMS Cost                      |                          |                |
| Total SMS Messages            | 420 leads × 3 SMS/lead   | 1,260 SMS      |

|                                      |                        |                 |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------|-----------------|
| SMS Cost ▾                           | 1,260 SMS × \$0.02/SMS | <b>\$25.20</b>  |
| AI / LLM and Infrastruct... ▾        | (Estimated Cost)       | <b>\$40.00</b>  |
| <b>Total Variable Cost (Per... ▾</b> | Voice + SMS + AI/Infra | <b>\$149.20</b> |

• **Gross Margin Calculation**

| Metric              | Value           |
|---------------------|-----------------|
| Revenue             | \$500.00        |
| Total Variable Cost | \$149.20        |
| <b>Gross Profit</b> | <b>\$350.80</b> |
| <b>Gross Margin</b> | <b>≈ 70%</b>    |

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-----**Contribution Margin at Scale (Benchmark: 167 Rooftops / \$1M ARR)**

| Metric                       | Calculation             | Monthly Value      | Annualized Value    |
|------------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------|---------------------|
| <b>Monthly Revenue (MRR)</b> | 167 rooftops × \$500    | <b>\$83,500</b>    | \$1,002,000         |
| <b>Monthly Cost</b>          | 167 rooftops × \$149.20 | <b>\$24,916.40</b> | \$298,996.80        |
| <b>Gross Profit</b>          | MRR - Monthly Cost      | <b>\$58,583.60</b> | <b>\$703,003.20</b> |

# ROI Drivers

ZOL delivers value through two primary performance levers: response speed and operational efficiency.

## Instant Response Improves Conversion

Inbound automotive leads are highly time-sensitive. ZOL engages every lead within seconds via voice, SMS, and email, eliminating delays that reduce appointment probability.

With approximately 700 inbound leads per rooftop per month, even a modest 3–5% improvement in appointment booking rate can generate meaningful incremental revenue.

Faster response directly translates to increased showroom traffic and higher vehicle sales.

## **Reduced BDC Labor Dependency**

Traditional BDC staffing typically costs \$3,000–\$6,000 per month per rooftop, operates within limited hours, and struggles with consistent multi-touch follow-up.

ZOL operates 24/7 at \$500 per month per rooftop, reducing reliance on outreach reps while maintaining structured, persistent engagement.

## **Traction**

### **Design Partnerships**

- Currently collaborating with 10 live dealership design partners.
- Zero attrition (churn) to date.
- Partnerships average 1–3 rooftops per dealership group.
- Conducting weekly product iteration sessions with sales reps and sales managers

### **Usage Metrics**

- Generating approximately 700 inbound leads per rooftop per month.
- Processing over 2,000+ leads till date across all active partners.
- The AI initiates engagement within seconds of lead submission.
- Utilizing multi-touch follow-up via voice, SMS, and email channels.

### **Product Validation**

- Dealers are actively contributing to the refinement of the operational playbook.
- Real-world Customer Relationship Management (CRM) and Dealer Management System (DMS) integration has been tested in a testing environment.
- A continuous feedback loop is in place to enhance booking logic and automation flows.

### **Pipeline**

- Engaged in active discussions with 10 additional dealership groups.
- Cultivating direct, founder-led relationships with dealer GM/ Sales-Manager and reps.
- Significant expansion opportunity exists within current accounts through multi-rooftop upsells.

# Growth strategy

## 1. Go-To-Market (Initial Penetration)

ZOL secures new dealership accounts through direct, founder-led outreach and comprehensive on-site discovery sessions.

- In-person consultations conducted at dealerships within Northern California.
- A 30-minute workflow interview is conducted with the Sales Manager or General Manager.
- A 7-day live pilot is implemented to demonstrate the system's response speed and follow-up consistency.
- Successful pilots transition to a formal subscription agreement at a rate of \$500 per month.

This initial approach has successfully secured 10 live design partners, maintaining a zero-percent churn rate.

## 2. Expansion Within Dealer Groups

The typical dealership group operates a portfolio ranging from 2 to 10 retail locations (rooftops).

Following the successful deployment of ZOL at a single rooftop:

- The strategy targets expansion into additional franchises within the same corporate group.
- Multi-rooftop deployment results in a reduced customer acquisition cost per rooftop.
- Centralized customization of the AI playbook enhances customer retention and platform stickiness.

This systematic expansion model facilitates compounding Annual Recurring Revenue (ARR) per customer account.

## 3. Regional Rollout Strategy

- Phase 1: Achieve market dominance within Northern California.
- Phase 2: Systematically expand to dealer groups across the West Coast.
- Phase 3: Implement a nationwide rollout strategy utilizing strategic partnerships and automated outbound sales processes.

## 4. Distribution Channels (Next 12 Months)

- Direct, founder-led sales initiatives.
- Leveraging referrals generated by existing dealer groups.
- Establishing integration partnerships with major Customer Relationship Management (CRM) and Dealer Management System (DMS) providers.

- Participation in key industry trade shows (e.g., NADA, Digital Dealer).
- Executing targeted outbound email campaigns utilizing specialized dealership databases.

## 5. Revenue Scaling Plan

To achieve a target of \$80,000 in Monthly Recurring Revenue (MRR):

- This requires securing 167 rooftops at a rate of \$500 per month.
- Given an average of 2 rooftops per dealership account.
- This necessitates approximately 85 total dealership accounts.

Strategic multi-rooftop expansion significantly mitigates the overall customer acquisition burden.

## 6. Long-Term Expansion

- Penetration of the used car dealership market segment.
- Development and introduction of AI analytics add-on modules.
- Targeting large-scale enterprise dealer groups.
- Strategic expansion into adjacent verticals characterized by high inbound volume.

# 12-Month Operating Budget

Category                      Annual Cost (\$)                      Monthly Avg (\$)

| Category                  | Annual Cost (\$) | Monthly Avg (\$) |
|---------------------------|------------------|------------------|
| 2 Engineers (\$120K each) | 240,000          | 20,000           |
| GTM                       | 60,000           | 5,000            |
| Legal & Compliance        | 40,000           | 3,333            |
| Tools & Ops               | 36,000           | 3,000            |
| Founders                  | 72,000           | 6,000            |
| Contingency (10%)         | 50,000           | -                |
| <b>Total</b>              | <b>498,000</b>   | <b>37,333</b>    |

Burn rate: ~\$37.5K/month including contingency buffer

## 12-Month Revenue Targets

### Assumptions:

- A monthly rate of \$500 per rooftop is assumed.
- The average dealership account is anticipated to encompass two rooftops.
- Approximately 85 dealership accounts will be required to achieve a Monthly Recurring Revenue (MRR) of \$80,000.

| Month | Target MRR | Rooftops Required | Dealership Accounts (Avg 2 rooftops) |
|-------|------------|-------------------|--------------------------------------|
| 3     | \$10,000   | 20                | 10                                   |
| 6     | \$25,000   | 50                | 25                                   |
| 9     | \$50,000   | 100               | 50                                   |
| 12    | \$80,000   | 160               | 80                                   |

## Funding Terms

| Metric                      | Detail                         |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Raising                     | \$500,000                      |
| Instrument                  | SAFE                           |
| Valuation Cap               | \$6,000,000                    |
| Minimum Check               | \$25,000                       |
| Lead Investor               | Open                           |
| Runway                      | 12 months                      |
| Milestone before next raise | \$80K MRR (~\$1M ARR run rate) |

### Use of Funds Allocation

| Category              | Percentage |
|-----------------------|------------|
| Product & Engineering | 55%        |

|                    |     |
|--------------------|-----|
| GTM                | 20% |
| Infrastructure     | 15% |
| Legal & Compliance | 10% |

Milestone before next raise: \$80K MRR (~\$1M ARR run rate)**Funding Summary**

This round is designed to reach revenue escape velocity before raising a larger institutional round.

## Key Risks

### 1. Product Reliability and AI Output Integrity

**Risk:** The potential for inconsistent AI-generated responses or the production of factually incorrect (hallucinated) information could significantly erode dealer confidence.

**Mitigation:**

- Deployment of structured, dealership-specific operating protocols (in lieu of reliance on free-form AI generation).
- Refinement of the model using human-curated and reviewed conversation datasets.
- Implementation of continuous Quality Assurance (QA) monitoring, complemented by robust fallback and escalation logic.
- Execution of a phased, gradual rollout strategy, supported by real-time performance analytics.

### 2. CRM/DMS Integration Stability

**Risk:** Instability within the Application Programming Interface (API) or unforeseen updates to Customer Relationship Management (CRM) or Dealer Management System (DMS) platforms could interrupt critical lead routing and appointment scheduling functions.

**Mitigation:**

- Establishment of redundant data ingestion mechanisms (incorporating email, API, and webhook pathways).
- Development of a modular integration architecture.
- Fostering close, collaborative relationships with dealership Information Technology (IT) teams.

- Pursuit of planned certification pathways with leading DMS providers.

### 3. Regulatory Compliance and Communication Standards

**Risk:** Non-adherence to regulatory mandates, including the Telephone Consumer Protection Act (TCPA), SMS consent protocols, or call recording regulations, presents substantial legal exposure.

**Mitigation:**

- Strict enforcement of explicit opt-in consent logic.
- Implementation of configurable and auditable consent management workflows.
- Allocation of a dedicated budget for legal review and compliance counsel.
- Maintenance of clear and comprehensive audit logs for all AI-facilitated communications.

### 4. Conversion Metrics and Return on Investment (ROI) Assumptions

**Risk:** Should the AI-driven follow-up system fail to demonstrably increase appointment bookings, it may preclude the conversion of pilot clients to long-term, paid subscriptions.

**Mitigation:**

- Structuring pilot deployments around clear, measurable ROI objectives.
- Adopting a regimen of rapid iteration informed by weekly feedback from dealer partners.
- Strategic prioritization of response velocity and follow-up persistence, which are established drivers of sales performance.
- Initiation of multi-rooftop expansion exclusively after rigorous validation of performance metrics.

## Team

### Ezaz Ahamad — Co-founder & CEO

- Ex-Berkeley Labs Researcher
- 2× AI research publications
- 7× hackathon winner
- Founders Inc & Zo World alum
- Ex-CTO of VC-backed company (~\$5M)

### Amol Bhalerao — Co-founder & CTO

- Master's in Data Science & AI
- 2× Startup Challenge winner
- Industry experience at Infosys & Tata Motors

- AI automation systems builder

**Bernie Knaus — Advisor & Mentor**

- 30+ years in automotive sales & dealership operations
- \$100M+ in vehicle sales across 16 countries
- Founder & President, NewAutos Inc
- Deep expertise in dealership BDC workflows, CRM adoption, and sales conversion optimization
- Active mentor supporting dealer partnerships and GTM strategy